

out JobSlinger.com. It costs nothing. (And be sure to read up on the latest mystery-shopping scams—I have never, ever, ever been asked to cash checks in my six years of shopping. Ever.)

After some time, I gave up on mystery shopping. The \$8–10 an hour wasn't worth the work (especially as my family grew). For some, this could still be a really good deal. Just be aware of the facts, and decide what's right for you. — **Linsey Knerl**

Sweeping 101: Secrets of Sweepstakes Winners

Hi, my name is Linsey, and I'm a sweeper. It is sometimes difficult to admit, but I belong to that persistent group of individuals who go to considerable lengths to enter sweepstakes. I also win fairly regularly. My winnings include a bicycle, a home automation system, two satellite radios, hotel stays, cell phones, gift cards, cash, DVDs, spa visits, clothing,

baby items, video games, gaming systems, office supplies, a digital camera and printer, a trip to San Francisco, and so much more! Winning is more about knowing than anything else, so I'm going to give you the basics to get started. You can't win if you don't enter!

WHAT IS A SWEEPSTAKES?

Simply put, a sweepstakes is a random drawing of entries for a prize. Generally sponsored or paid for by companies wishing to promote their products or services, sweepstakes are a billion-dollar marketing tactic used by thousands of companies a year. You should never have to purchase anything to enter. If a sweepstakes requires a UPC, special form from a product, or a "winning game piece," there will always be an alternate means of entry, or it is not a legal sweepstakes. If entry into a sweepstakes requires an entry fee or raffle ticket purchase, it is not a true sweepstakes.

WHERE DO I FIND SWEEPSTAKES?

While sweepstakes are simply hard to avoid these days, there are some